C1 Reading

Following an argument: reference words

Track what this, which, such, the former and the latter point back to, so long texts stay clear.

Academic writers avoid repeating nouns by using reference words. If you lose track of what a word refers to, you lose the argument. Train yourself to find the referent every time.

Reference word	Usually refers to	Example
this / that / these	An idea or noun just mentioned	*Prices rose sharply. This led to protests.*
which (after a comma)	The noun just before it, or the whole previous clause (as here)	*Sales fell, which worried investors.*
such + noun	Things of the type just described	*Such measures are rarely popular.*
the former / the latter	The first / second of two things	*Solar and wind power are growing; the latter is cheaper.*
it / they / them	The nearest suitable noun	*The reports were late because they needed checking.*

Text

> Many cities have introduced congestion charges or car-free zones. The former raise money that can be spent on public transport, while the latter make streets safer for pedestrians. Critics argue that such schemes hurt small shops, which depend on customers who drive. This concern, however, is not supported by recent studies, many of which show that footfall actually increases once traffic is reduced.

Ask "this what?" When you see a bare *this*, add a noun in your head: *this concern*, *this change*. Good writers often add it for you.

Common mistake. Assuming *it* or *they* always refers to the subject of the last sentence. Check meaning: *Critics argue that such schemes hurt small shops, which depend on customers*: *which* refers to the shops, not the schemes.

Practice

What does each word refer to?

1. *The former* (sentence 2)
2. *the latter* (sentence 2)
3. *such schemes*
4. *which* (in "which depend on customers")
5. *This concern*
6. *many of which*

▼ **Show answers**

1. congestion charges
2. car-free zones
3. congestion charges and car-free zones
4. small shops
5. the claim that the schemes hurt small shops
6. recent studies